

# ASHMITA

## bags maiden BWF Tour title

**A**shmita Chaliha won her first BWF World Tour title after completing a comeback win over China's Han Qian Xi in the women's singles final at the BWF Korea Masters. The 26-year-old from Guwahati conceded the first game but came roaring back to win 14-21, 21-14, 21-14 in 53 minutes against the fourth-seeded Chinese. The World No. 50 trailed 9-11 in the deciding game but made full use of the favourable drift from the other side of the court to reel in 12 out of the last 15 points and seal victory.

Ashmita, who trains under Park Tae-sang at the National Centre of Excellence in Guwahati, had defeated top seed Hina Akechi of Japan in the quarterfinal before seeing off compatriot Rakshita Ramraj in the semis.

Victory at the Korea Masters marks a second consecutive women's singles title for India after Tanvi Sharma's recent victory at the Taipei Open. Ashmita and Tanvi join a list of just five Indian athletes to win a women's singles BWF Tour title, the other three being Saina Nehwal, P. V. Sindhu and Devika Sihag.

Ashmita said that winning her maiden BWF World Tour title at the Korea Masters has left her wanting more. "I feel really great and unbelievable. But then I am trying to digest it. Now, I am hungry for more," she said.

"In the first game, it was a little bit tricky because of the drift conditions, so I was not able to manage it... But in the second, the other side was more comfortable, and there was less drift, so I was able to control it. And in the third, after 11 points, I changed again, so I was on the good side. I'm glad that I could pull off," she added.

Ashmita had suffered a career-threatening knee injury two years back in Korea. "Before the injury, Ashmita was already a good player and a very good talent. She has a good smash and nice movement, but unfortunately, at the wrong time, she had to take a break because of the injury," her coach Park Tae-sang

said. "When she joined me, I thought, 'Oh, she is a good player.' But tactically and strategically, and also a little bit mentally, she had some problems. Before the final here, we did a video analysis of her Chinese opponent. I told Ashmita, 'Your biggest problem is your own mistakes. You are making simple mistakes. But if you can reduce those simple mistakes by 100 per cent, I promise you, you can win the title today. In the first game, she played well. But in the second game, again, she started making easy mistakes. When the second game finished, I told her, 'Ashmita, think about the first game and think about the second game. What was the difference?' The reason was very simple. In the second game, you made too many mistakes. If you reduce those mistakes, you have a big chance because today's opponent, Han, is normally a rally player. She doesn't have a very powerful smash; she doesn't have much deception, and she is not particularly strong around the front court. So I told her very strongly again, 'Ashmita, you have to change your game,'" Park explained.

"At the beginning of the third game, up to 11 points, Han was playing a little faster than Ashmita. So I told her, 'From this point, you have to play more aggressively. You have a good smash and good power. Why are you making mistakes with drop shots? Why are you making mistakes with your clears? Just use your smash.' And she did it," he concluded.

**Sky is the limit:** Ashmita said that winning her maiden BWF World Tour title at the Korea Masters has left her wanting more. "I feel really great and unbelievable. But then I am trying to digest it. Now, I am hungry for more," she said.

GETTY IMAGES

